

What is Archaeology?

When we hear the term **archaeology**, most people think of one of the fictional creations of Hollywood, such as Indiana Jones or Lara Croft. Some think about pyramids, graves filled with treasure, or the Great Wall of China. These representations all have some element of truth to them but do not represent the true discipline of archaeology. Archaeology is a science, a social science, akin to anthropology, sociology, or psychology. Archaeologists are professional researchers who attempt to understand the human past. So, how is archaeology different from history? Archaeologists use **material remains**, the physical traces of human activity, as our primary source of evidence, while historians use written documents as theirs. Since writing has only been around for a few thousand years, but human ancestors date to more than a million years ago, only archaeology has the tools to study the entire history of humankind, from our earliest evolution through the first tools and use of fire, beginnings of art, origins of social class and status, and rise of cities. Most relevant for this class, however, archaeology provides a unique perspective on the development of our food systems—from simple foraging to complex modifications of environments, plants, and animals—to produce food on a massive scale, such as we see today.

Archaeology is the scientific study of the human past through the analysis of material remains

Material remains are any physical traces of human activity that are tangible. These include **artifacts**, objects created by humans, and a category often termed **ecofacts**—aspects of the natural world shaped by humans, such as the remains of food. Examples of artifacts include stone tools (often called lithics), pottery, and even buildings. Examples of ecofacts include uneaten portions of plants, animal bones,

and ashes from a wood fire. Note that archaeologists may sometimes classify all of these traces of human activity (including ecofacts) as artifacts!

Look at these images

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Which of the images represent artifacts? Which are ecofacts?
Which are both or neither?



- ☐ Artifact ☐ Ecofact ☐ Both ☐ Neither